2026-11-01 — שיר של יום, אתה הראת, and the Origins of the Haftarah — Or Zarua, Soferim, and the Greek Decree

Independent review · read fresh from the HTML alone, no transcript consulted · 1 November 2026 · 21 Cheshvan 5787 · final (Sefaria-corrected) draft

1.Overall Read

An eight-section write-up of roughly 5,600 words of body (plus a 166-word abstract and a 25-note *Mareh Mekomos* of about 2,500 words). It follows one thread, the order of the Shabbos morning service after the Amidah, and then widens into the origins of the haftarah. The path: the שיר של יום and why Ashkenazim say it after Musaf (I); who opens the ark (II); the verses said as the Torah comes out, via *Masechet Soferim*, the Or Zarua and the exiled families of Rome (III); אתה הראת and ויהי בנסע הארן (IV); the מי שברך after each aliyah (V); Rashi's "daily haftarah" (VI); the Avudraham's "Greek decree," Elijah Levita and the Christian Hebraists (VII); and three questions from the room (VIII).

The hard problems are six. (a) **The piece has no spine.** Its title names three topics, the abstract names a fourth (the מי שברך), and the body wanders through at least eight. The one real argument, two rival accounts of where the haftarah comes from, begins at VI, about two-thirds of the way in. (b) **Digressions outweigh the argument.** III spends about 1,200 words on the Or Zarua's dream, the spelling of עקיבא in a גט and the four families exiled to Rome; VII spends most of its length on Elijah Levita, a cardinal and whether one may teach Torah to a gentile, before it answers the question it set (when was the decree?) in one paragraph at the very end. (c) **Several sentences contradict each other or the notes** (the Magen Avraham, the Rema and the

chasan, who restored the Soferim verses, the triennial cycle); see Section 4. (d) **The body keeps presenting as fact what the notes cannot find.** Roughly fourteen of twenty-five notes are "UNCERTAIN," and the body reads flatly. (e) **The conversational scaffolding is still on the page:** jokes about the shul's balance, the kiddush club, a named gabbai, "see the note," "the purchaser is named on the recording." (f) **No conclusion.** After setting Rashi against the Avudraham, the text never says which the Rav prefers or whether they can both be true, and ends on a halachic aside about מחר חודש and a preview of next week.

2.What Works

- **The fresh central question.** "Where does the haftarah come from?" and the "very radical מחלוקת" between Rashi (a chapter of Prophets every day) and the Avudraham (a substitute for a banned Torah reading) is a genuinely interesting contrast, and the Rav's framing "this is all Jewish history" is the right tone for a book.
- **Rashi's five-part list (VI).** The idea that before work a person should have read מקרא, נביא, משנה, ברייתא and גמרא, with the Rav tracing where each is already built into davening (קריאת שמע, איזהו מקומן, אלו דברים, רבי ישמעאל אומר, ובא לציון), is the best thing in the piece. It is concrete, checkable and makes the reader look at his own siddur.
- **"Rabbasah ha'aniyus."** The reason the daily reading lapsed (people were poor and had to work) is human, and the Rav's reaction ("sad to read it") is quotable.
- **The Rambam / ark of the covenant haftarah (VI).** A haftarah chosen for an event, with the Rav's reading that the Rambam was "like the ארון, the power of Torah of his generation," is vivid.
- **The pastoral touches.** The Rav standing beside the ark and telling a young father "Don't just open it and take out the Torah. Daven!" (II) and

the woman in the ezras nashim who comes for the מי שברך לחולים (V) show the shiur's purpose better than any lomdus.

- **Candor in the notes.** The notes say plainly where a source was not found, and they correct the Rav on Menachos 99b and on the vow passage (Shabbos 32b, not Nedarim).
- **Pointed Hebrew on the key verse.** אַתָּה הָרְאֵתָ לָדַעַת is displayed pointed (IV), which helps.

3.Where It's Weak or Could Be Sharper

Decide what the chapter is about and say so on page one. The title promises אתה הראת, שיר של יום and the haftarah; the abstract adds the מי שברך and the Or Zarua's dream. A reader cannot tell whether this is "the Shabbos morning Torah service," "customs of Eretz Yisrael that reached us," or "the haftarah." The strongest title is the last of these, and the first five sections become the setup (what happens between Musaf and the haftarah) in about a third of their present length. At minimum, rename sections: "I. Dedication, and the Placement of Shir Shel Yom" is two unrelated things.

Section I. The Sefardic / Ashkenazic placement of the song is hard to follow: "Nusach Sefard says it after Shacharis, and the Sefardim have already said שיר של יום; Ashkenazim also say it there, yet מנהג ספרד goes out of its way..." uses "Sefardim," "Nusach Sefard" and "the Sefardic way" for what may be two different things. The section then asks the Musaf-song question and answers it with "Someone offers an answer... the Rav points out that *Soferim* spells out the songs." That is a non sequitur. And "Every time there's a Musaf, they say, now we can learn Torah" cannot be understood by anyone who was not in the room. The Nitra, Young Israel of Woodmere, "decorum committee" and "Beis Yeshayah has no such committee" material (about 250 words) is communal anecdote; a book chapter needs one sentence: some shuls moved the song earlier because of noise after Musaf.

Section II reads as filler. The purchase of the Torah-removal honor on

Simchas Torah, the Chida's מנהג ותיקין for a man whose wife is in her ninth month, and the groom are three customs under a heading ("Who Opens the Ark?") that sounds like a halachic discussion. The Or Zarua is introduced here, as "one of the great ראשונים Rav of Vienna... in the 1200s," and introduced again at the start of III as "one of the בעלי התוספות and the chief rabbi of Vienna." One introduction is enough. The Chida paragraph (the Rav at the ark) is the best of the section; keep that and shrink the rest.

The Or Zarua / Shibbolei HaLeket / four families sequence (III) is the largest digression. The dream story, the ספ׳ spelling, the aside on פנחס "a huge תלוקת he wrote a whole sefer about this" (who?), Rabbi Moshe Langer, the Rhine, and then the Shibbolei HaLeket author's name ("רב אברהם בן צדקי think קיהו בן אברהם הרופא") are all there to answer one question: who put the Soferim verses into our siddur? The answer, in one line, is the Or Zarua (and, in the Rav's telling, Rav Avraham the doctor). The reader is also not told why the Or Zarua's name matters to the verses at all: the dream story explains the *name of the sefer*, not the *custom*. Cut to the verse-and-name punchline in two sentences and move the gittin detail to a note, if kept.

Section IV is the shortest and the cleanest, and it is the least developed. At 219 words, את הראה gets a single reason (the Torah was given on Shabbos) from the Tur. The most interesting lines are buried in the middle of a paragraph: Nusach Ashkenaz does not say it at all, and the Tur was in Spain. Say in one sentence that this is another Sefard / Ashkenaz split of exactly the kind the chapter keeps circling. Also resolve a small inconsistency: III says that on Shabbos "we say את התה הראת and other verses that differ from the weekday ones," while IV says "all the other verses are left out on Shabbos."

Section V runs two unrelated ideas under one heading. (1) The מי שברך after an aliyah is tied to a pledge ("For money"), with the Rav's practical point about the text (עבור שיתן מתנה versus עבור שצוה לברכם); (2) the מי שברך לחולים and the Beis Yosef's answer that it is a blessing, not a prayer. Between them sit a frightening warning about vows and a joke about the Rav's own balance. Separate them: V.1 the pledge, V.2 the sick. Also, the Rav's claim "That was the original מנהג for עבור שיתן מתנה is given with no source,

and the Midrash in Vayikra Rabbah and Kohelet Rabbah is described only as "an ancient custom... in the merit of the Torah open on the בימה

Section VI. (a) Rashi's list has five items; the walk-through fulfils four (נביא, כתובים, משנה, ברייתא) and never reaches ארון הקודש. (b) The sub-section "Haftaros that match the day" is placed under "First view: Rashi," and closes "That is Rashi's view in sum." But it includes the Rambam (d. 1204) and Rav Sherira Gaon, who are not Rashi's sources (Rashi died in 1105 and wrote before the Rambam's death), and a Rema custom: this is the history of the haftarah after Rashi, not Rashi's view. Give it its own sub-heading and its own introduction. (c) "The reading did not have to be בספר המאורע" and "there are blessings before and after, as part of Rashi's שיטה" are asserted with no support. (d) Jokes at the expense of the congregation (the kiddush club, a חתן every week in a Sefardic shul, "שרה, שרה, the portion of בלעם" are fine live and weak on the page.

Section VII is built backwards. The Avudraham's account (a decree against reading the Torah, so twenty-one verses of Prophets in its place) takes one paragraph. The question the Rav then poses ("when was there a decree... that you could daven but not read from the Torah, though you could read from the Prophets?") is answered by Elijah Levita's *Tishbi* in the last paragraph of the section: מלכות יון, Antiochus, plus the Levush's note that Kesuvim were also banned. Between the question and the answer stand about 500 words on Levita's biography, his friendships with cardinals and Münster, and whether one may teach a gentile. Put the answer immediately after the question, and move Levita to a boxed sidebar or a note. The question about teaching gentiles (Igros Moshe, Sanhedrin 59a) is a new halachic topic in the middle of a historical one. In print, "a חכם that learns Torah is מיתה ביד שמים, it's a terrible thing" and "they became even bigger Christians" need framing or removal; the Rav's actual point (Levita probably drew criticism and the results were mixed) can be made in a sentence.

The logic of the twenty-one verses. VII says the haftarah is twenty-one verses "because Shabbos has seven aliyos and each needs at least three verses (3 × 7)." But in the same paragraph the decree is the reason the haftarah exists,

and the decree was a ban on reading the Torah. Why would the replacement be sized by the number of Torah aliyos? Either the Avudraham's own reasoning needs a sentence of explanation, or the text should say "the Rav explains."

Section VIII does not belong where it is. The triennial cycle, seven aliyos and מחר חודש are three separate questions, each opening a new topic and none connected to the two views of the haftarah. "Machar Chodesh" is the only one that bears on the haftarah's relation to the day. Either fold the triennial point into VI (as evidence for "the haftarah matched the portion") and drop the aliyos question to a note, or retitle VIII "Three Further Questions" and say plainly they are loose ends. The ending, a preview of next week and the concluding line צוה הקדוש ברוך הוא לזכות את ישראל is a customary close but leaves the reader without a conclusion.

Cross-references to shiurim the book reader has not seen. "As discussed when the series covered Monday and Thursday" (VI, twice); "we learned this when we learned the weekday Tefillah"; "as discussed last week" (V); "a question from a couple of weeks ago"; "the chapter learned in the Thursday night shiur two weeks ago"; "I only found it out this morning" (three times); "much of this was discussed." Replace with chapter pointers or delete.

Names and private details. A named sponsor's mother (I), the shul "Beis Yeshayah," the Young Israel of Woodmere and "Rabbi Billet," Nitra, Rabbi Moshe Langer, "the son of a dear friend of the shul," a woman who telephoned the Rav, and "a congregant" or "a participant" about twenty times. Keep the dedication (two lines). Everyone else becomes "a member of the shul" or goes. The Rav's remark on his own unpaid pledges ("that's why my bill in the shul is...") should go.

4.Factual / Citation Concerns

The Magen Avraham on the song of the day (I, notes 2 and 3).

The body has "the Magen Avraham holds that the Sefardic way, שיר של after Shacharis, is correct," and, earlier, that he finds the Ashkenazic practice of saying it after Musaf makes "no sense." Note 2 reports that the Magen Avraham as retrieved says that on days with Musaf the song is said after Shacharis *and* after Musaf. The body should say "as the Rav understands the Magen Avraham."

"Italy, as in the rest of Ashkenaz" (III). The text says Rav Avraham the doctor "saw that in Italy, as in the rest of Ashkenaz, nothing was said." Italy is not Ashkenaz. This also sits oddly with the immediately preceding claim that the practice "comes from the Or Zarua"; the reader is left asking whether the verses were revived by the Or Zarua (Rhineland, 13th century) or by Rav Avraham in Rome, and the Rav's phrase "from that point on in history, כל ישראל all over says these verses" credits the

second. State one account and attribute the other as a variant.

The Rema and the chasan (VI). The body says "the א" מ brings a custom regarding a תתן. The Sefardim adopted it, and 'we don't do it'." Rema is the Ashkenazic authority; "we don't do it" and "the Sefardim adopted it" run backwards from what a reader expects, and note 18 says the Rema glosses on Orach Chaim 282 and 284 do not mention it. Print it as "the Rav reports a custom, which he attributes to the Rema, of reading שוש אשיש for a chasan on his aufruf."

The triennial cycle (VIII). The body has "the מנהג בני בבל who read the Torah over three years." The triennial cycle was the custom of Eretz Yisrael; Babylonia read annually. Benjamin of Tudela's Cairo shul (next to the Rambam's) was the Palestinian-rite congregation. Either the Rav

misspoke and the text should correct it, or "Bavel" is a mistranscription. It also contradicts the logic of III, which treats Soferim's Eretz Yisrael customs as the old, rival practice.

The Rambam and the Rav Sherira haftaros (VI, note 19). The body puts these under the heading of Rashi's view and says the haftarah was changed "throughout Eretz Yisrael" for the Rambam, who died in Egypt. It also says the Rambam died "somewhere in Shevat" while note 19 gives 20 Tevet. A book needs the correct date and place in the text, and the phrase "ראשונים write" needs a source: an event of 1204 cannot be known to Rashi, and Rav Sherira died about two centuries earlier than the Rishonim who report it. If the source cannot be named, hedge: "a tradition the Rav relates."

"Rashi" in the Sefer HaPardes (VI, note 16). The Sefer HaPardes is attributed to Rashi's school, not to Rashi himself; the body hedges ("a sefer that quotes much from him") but the very next lines say "Rashi writes" | "ברשב"ם העניות" and "according to Rashi" nine times. Use "the Pardes (in Rashi's name)" and cite once.

Sefer HaTishbi (VII, note 21). The body calls it "a very rare sefer" which "we only discovered in the 1500s." Levita wrote it in the 1500s and it was printed in his lifetime (Isny, 1541); it is not rare and was not "discovered." Note 21 already says it was composed then. Fix in the body. Also say "the Tishbi" is the source for the decree, not just a book by the same man; the reader has to infer it.

The Levush and Kesuvim (VII). "The Levush adds, in the laws of

Shabbos א"	רפ" The Levush's treatment of the haftarah is at 284

(note 20 cites the Rema there); 281 is the siman for	אתה הראת(NV).

The Rav's "It's a Gemara in Megillah, but nobody knows why" is

unspecified: which Gemara says that the haftarah is only from Nevi'im?

Note 20 says the Levush was not retrieved. The sentence "Maybe the

Greeks thought the Prophets were okay to read" is the Rav's own wonder,

as note 20 says; mark it.

Seven aliyos and Barchu (VIII, note 24). The text says a once-a-

week attender "had missed six (the Rav first says seven) recitations of

' המבורך	בּרכו את הA person who comes only on Shabbos misses far

more than six on the weekdays. The count is not explained, and "the Rav

first says seven" is sound-recording residue. Either explain the arithmetic

or write "the Barchu he missed during the week."

The עקיבה / עקיבא claims (III, note 8). "Throughout the Yerushalmi and the Tosefta... the name is written with a עקיבה Throughout ה'... the Bavli and the Mishnayos... with an אלף is a sweeping manuscript claim that the note could not confirm. Also "you get for the רבי עקיבא last letters of the verse is not accurate as printed: the letters spell ע-ק-י-ב-ה, and the ה stands for the first word, not for "Rabbi." Print the letters and explain.

The vow passage (V, note 14). The body says "the Gemara in Nedarim" and tells the reader to "see the note"; the note says it is Shabbos 32b. Put the correct source in the body. Also attribute clearly: the Rav says "I don't want to say what the Midrash says because it's very scary" and then reports a Gemara, so the reader does not know whether the Midrash or the Gemara is the source of the threat.

The Soferim verses (III, note 7). The body says Soferim contains "many more verses than our סידור and that it "would literally take a half hour to an hour." Note 7 verifies only that Soferim 14:8 has a long series. The body should say "a long series." The statement that בריך שמיה "comes from the Zohar" is likewise a claim by the Rav, supported in the note only by reference to an earlier shiur.

Date. 1 November 2026 = 21 Cheshvan 5787 (25 October was 14 Cheshvan): correct, and consistent with the previous page. The kicker reads "Rabbi Ephrati" while the project folder says "Efratti"; use one spelling throughout.

Footnotes and the "Flag" lines: what a book edition must resolve or move to endnotes

All twenty-five notes carry a "VERIFIED," "UNCERTAIN," or "CORRECTED" line.

Sorted by what the flag says:

- **Verified or partly verified:** 1 (Tamid 7:4), 3 (Magen Avraham), 7 (Soferim

14:8, partly), 8 (verse only), 12 (Tur 281), 13 (Bamidbar 10:35), 20 (Rema 284, partly), 22 (Sanhedrin 59a), 24 (Megillah 23a). Reduce to clean one-line citations.

- **Corrected the Rav:** 14 (Nedarim to Shabbos 32b), 17 (Menachos 90 to 99b). Both corrections must also appear in the body, where only 17 now has them (in a parenthesis).

- **Oral report or custom:** 4, 5, 9, 10, 11, 21, 23. Print as attributed reports or drop.

- **Genuinely unresolved:** 2 (the Magen Avraham's actual words), 6 (Chida; no sefer), 15 (Avkas Rochel), 16 (Pardes), 18 (Rema), 19 (Rambam / Rav Sherira), 25 (Magen Avraham). Seven or eight notes needing a library visit or softening.

Problems that apply to the apparatus as a whole:

- **Platform language.** "Sefaria," "Sofer.ai," "the Plaud summary," "the recording," "as retrieved" and "not fetched" appear in many notes; a book cites the work and place, and the editorial log is a separate document.

- **Body text that is itself note-like.** "(The purchaser is named on the recording...)," "(the Rav forgets the exact date...)," "(The Rav says daf ; it is 99b)," "the fourth name is not given on the recording," "(The Rav ascribes this to the Gemara in Nedarim; see the note.)" and "[the Sefardim do]" in square brackets all belong to the web edition only.

- **Several notes are longer than the sentence they explain,** and a few (2, 14, 20) mix a source, a correction and editorial doubt in one paragraph. Split each into a clean citation and a log line.

- **Section-heading drift.** The notes' headings are tidy; the body headings ("It's a peleh": why after Musaf?, "Nitra, Young Israel of Woodmere, and

> the decorum committee") are quotations and local anecdotes. Use topic headings.

5.Small Polish Suggestions

- **Transliteration to unify:** *Hareisa* (heading) versus *Hareita* and אתה הראת; *Mi Sheberach* versus *mi sheberach* (notes); *Mareh Mekomos* (the notes' heading) versus *Mareh Mekamos* (the project name); *Rabbi Ephrati* versus *Efratti*; *aliyah* / *aliyos* / עלייה; *Avudraham* versus *Abudraham*; *Eliyahu Bachur* versus *Elijah Levita* (use both once, then one); *Shacharis*, *Mincha*, *Musaf* are fine.
- **Yiddish and slang.** " נישט מער" ,"אויבערלאנד אשכנזיש" ,"שמועס" ,"בלאגן גיב" ,"ליינען" ,"מוראדיקע קשיא" ,"חמור'דיגע חידוש" ,"וואכעדיגע זאך" ,"געדאכט אכט" and "לאנגע געזונטע יארן" appear untranslated. Gloss the few worth keeping and cut the rest.
- **Hebrew pointing policy.** The one verse in IV is pointed; the אור זרוע לצדיק verse, the שוש אשיש verse and the מי שברך texts are unpointed. Print the verse in III with the last letters marked, which would make the dream story self-explanatory.
- **The Hebrew spelling of the abstract and kicker.** The abstract uses הוצאת ספר תורה, מי שברך and עלייה in running English; a book reader in English will want transliteration plus translation at first mention.
- **The abstract** (about 110 words) is serviceable but misses the Rashi / Avudraham contrast as the thesis; lead with it.
- **"The Rav"** is used as the subject of almost every paragraph of I and III; in the book convert the lomdus to direct exposition and keep the reporting voice for the stories (the dream, the Rambam, the woman at the מי שברך).
- **Jokes at the end of sentences** ("because I need a coffee," "Talk to the אייבערשטער") are charming but cumulatively make the piece feel

transcribed rather than written. Keep two or three of the best.

- **Heading of VII.** "The Second View" and its sub-heads "Elijah Levita and the Christian Hebraists," "A question from the room" are not equal in weight to "The Greek decree." Reorder so the decree is the sub-heading the reader sees first.

Consolidated recommended edits (for the Sefer Edition rewrite)

1. Retitle and reframe the chapter around the haftarah's two origins; present I through V as a compact "what happens before the reading" opening, in roughly a third of the present length.
2. Cut the Or Zarua dream, the gittin spelling aside, the four families and the Shibbolei HaLeket genealogy to a few lines; state who is credited with restoring the Soferim verses (one account only) and list the other as a variant.
3. Split V into the pledge and the sick; move the Gemara citation to Shabbos 32b in the body.
4. Move "Haftaros that match the day" out from under Rashi; fix the Rema / chasan and Rambam passages (source, date, place, Egypt).
5. Rewrite VII so the decree's date (Antiochus) follows immediately after the question; box or cut Levita and the teaching-gentiles discussion; fix "rare" and "discovered."
6. Explain the 3 × 7 logic or attribute it to the Rav; correct the triennial cycle (Eretz Yisrael, not Bavel).
7. Fold VIII into the argument or label it as loose ends; add a closing paragraph that says what the two views share and which the Rav leans to.
8. Remove names, banter, the unpaid-balance joke, "the kiddush club," and every "as discussed last week" reference.

9. Move the CORRECTED notes into the body and strip platform language from the notes.

6.Bottom Line

> *A lively, learned and generous write-up whose best material, Rashi's five-part daily list, the "נה העניות" reason the custom lapsed and the Avudraham's Greek decree, arrives late and is surrounded by tangents. As a web page it works, and its notes are honest. As a book chapter it needs a spine (the two origins of the haftarah), a tighter first half, an ordering in which each question is followed at once by its answer, and the corrections that currently live in the notes (Shabbos 32b, 20 Tevet and Egypt, the triennial cycle, the Tishbi, Italy not Ashkenaz) moved into the body. Cut the names and the banter, end with a short conclusion that weighs Rashi against the Avudraham, and it would stand as a Sefer Edition chapter.*

Independent editorial review of the English write-up only. The reviewer read the HTML as a stranger would and did not consult the recording, the transcripts, or the earlier reviews. *caveat lector*.